

UPSC Philosophy Optional Paper 1 Simulation

QUESTION PAPER | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

INSTRUCTIONS

1. The paper has two sections, A and B, and eight questions.
2. Question 1 and Question 5 are compulsory.
3. Answer three other questions, choosing at least one from each section.
4. Answer five questions in all. The marks carried by each subpart are indicated.

SECTION A - Socio-Political Philosophy

Q1 (COMPULSORY)

- (a) "A classification of governments that counts rulers without asking whom they serve explains nothing." Comment. [10 marks]
- (b) "A composite index of development is evidence, not a theory of the good society." Comment. [10 marks]
- (c) Distinguish legal from political sovereignty, and explain why the distinction matters for evaluating Austin. [10 marks]
- (d) Critically examine the challenges faced by a multicultural society with reference to India. [10 marks]
- (e) Discuss the main factors responsible for caste discrimination. [10 marks]

Q2

- (a) "Monarchy, theocracy and democracy differ less in who rules than in how error is corrected." Discuss. [20 marks]
- (b) "Democracy is best defined by its method, not by its outcome." Critically examine with reference to Schumpeter. [15 marks]
- (c) Critically examine the claim that modernisation describes a neutral and inevitable process of social transformation. [15 marks]

Q3

- (a) "Sustainable development is a policy formula, not a philosophy." Critically discuss with reference to moral standing, duties to future persons and the distribution of ecological burdens. [20 marks]
- (b) Assess the significance of the pluralist lineage - Figgis, Cole and MacIver - for Laski's rejection of monistic sovereignty. [15 marks]
- (c) Can humanism be a substitute for religion? Explain and evaluate in the context of the present Indian society. [15 marks]

Q4

- (a) Critically examine the claim that the four printed thinkers on sovereignty are answering four different questions rather than giving four answers to one. [20 marks]
- (b) Critically analyse the social and political significance of Ambedkar's notion of annihilation of caste. [15 marks]
- (c) Can Theocracy be accepted as a valid form of Government? Give reasons and justification in support of your answer. [15 marks]

SECTION B - Philosophy of Religion

Q5 (COMPULSORY)

- (a) "Liberation is a family-resemblance term, not the name of a single state." Examine this claim with reference to at least four Indian schools. [10 marks]

- (b) "Analogy protects transcendence only by sacrificing intelligibility." Examine with reference to Aquinas and Scotus. (Answer within 150 words.) [10 marks]
- (c) Does the fact that religion motivates moral conduct show anything about the grounding of moral obligation? Examine. [10 marks]
- (d) Explain how Buddhism can sustain a religious form of life without belief in a creator God. [10 marks]
- (e) Discuss the paradox of omnipotence of God in the context of the existence of evil. [10 marks]

Q6

- (a) Can reason assess a claimed revelation without becoming its final authority? Critically examine the relation between faith, reason and revelation. [20 marks]
- (b) "Karma explains the distribution of suffering, but the explanation carries a moral cost." Discuss with reference to the theistic and non-theistic schools. [15 marks]
- (c) How far does Jain many-sidedness (anekantavada) resolve the problem of conflicting religious truth-claims? (Answer in about 250 words.) [15 marks]

Q7

- (a) Compare the God-world-human relation in Spinoza, Samkara and Ramanuja, and assess which model best preserves both metaphysical ultimacy and religious life. [20 marks]
- (b) "Karma answers the question that secular ethics leaves open, but at a cost of its own." Critically discuss. [15 marks]
- (c) Discuss the relationship between man and God according to any one of the religions in India. [15 marks]

Q8

- (a) Discuss the main points of distinction between a priori and a posteriori arguments for the existence of God. Which one according to you should be preferred over the other? Give reasons and justifications for your answer. [20 marks]
- (b) Examine whether a quality-transcending absolute can perform the religious functions performed by a personal God. [15 marks]
- (c) What role do the concepts of evil and profane play to provide a firm foundation to religion? [15 marks]

END OF PAPER